Karl Ernst von Baer — Über Entwickelungsgeschichte der Thiere: Beobachtung und Reflexion (1828 / 1837)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas.
Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Karl Ernst von Baer, discoverer of the mammalian ovum and the notochord and founder of comparative embryology, who watched embryos closely enough to see what they do not do. His laws, set out in this work, hold that development proceeds from the general to the specific, and that the embryos of different animals resemble each other's embryos, never each other's adults — a standing answer to recapitulation, given a generation before Haeckel made the answer necessary. Darwin leaned on von Baer, and embryologists have cited this book ever since, although almost none of them can read it. He also left the work itself unfinished: its final part appeared only in 1888, twelve years after his death. This presentation is dedicated to the observer whose title promises both observation and reflection, and to keeping those two halves together.

The author's own terms

The Scholien, in von Baer's use in this work, are his reflective commentaries: the passages in which observation turns to reflection, and where his laws live.

The story

Karl Ernst von Baer (1792–1876) discovered the mammalian ovum and the notochord, and founded comparative embryology — the study of how embryos develop, compared across animals. His great work, *Über Entwickelungsgeschichte der Thiere: Beobachtung und Reflexion*, "On the Developmental History of Animals: Observation and Reflection," appeared at Königsberg in two volumes, the first in 1828 and the second in 1837. It is the book in which "von Baer's laws" live, and the laws repay stating plainly. Development proceeds from the general to the specific: an embryo first shows the broad characters of its large group, and only later its species and individual form. And the embryos of different animals resemble each other's embryos, never each other's adults. That second point was a standing rebuttal to recapitulation — the idea that an embryo climbs through the adult forms of its ancestors — stated a generation before Haeckel made the rebuttal necessary. Darwin leaned on von Baer.

Embryologists have cited this book ever since, constantly. Almost none of them can read it. English readers have only ever had the laws themselves, in a rendering of an excerpt, while the great observational surveys, the explanations of the plates, and the whole reflective half of the book — the philosophical half, announced in its very title — have no English existence in the sources consulted for this research.

The work and what survives

Both volumes are scanned on Internet Archive, under identifiers including `berentwickelun01baer`, `b29331936_0002` and `_0003`, `b24989794_0002`, and `bub_gb_ngc5ehai_HIC`, and on Google Books. The work is in the public domain: imprints of 1828 and 1837, and the author died in 1876.

A reviewer's check adds two facts that shape any edition. First, the work as Baer left it is incomplete by design: Volume I appeared in 1828, Volume II, part 1, in 1837, and a final part II/2, edited by Ludwig Stieda, was published posthumously in 1888, twelve years after Baer's death. Wellcome catalogues the whole as "2 volumes in 3" (1828–1888). A completable edition must therefore rule explicitly on including the Stieda part. Second, the scan record is now pinned: Biodiversity Heritage Library Item 28306 for the 1828–37 Bornträger edition, plus HathiTrust page images (key ha006055138) and a full PDF of Volume 2 hosted by UNSW Embryology. The reviewer concurs with the verdict of this research, and ranks Volume I — the chick, and the Scholien, the reflective commentaries where the laws live — as the realistic first tranche. A companion file in this collection treats

von Baer's *Addresses*, including the 245-page "Über Darwins Lehre."

Its English fortunes

The single English channel has been T. H. Huxley's rendering of the laws for the *Scientific Memoirs* — an excerpt. The surveys, the plates' explanations, and the *Reflexion* half of the book have no English existence in the sources consulted (Arizona State's Embryo Project page and the standard biographies).

The bounded finding of this research, verified on 14 October 2026, is this: **No complete English translation found after research.**

What completing it would take

Completing the work would mean a translation of both volumes from the German, in two instalments matching the original division, with an explicit ruling on the posthumous Stieda part. The Scholien — the reflections — are the soul of the book and must not be trimmed; an edition that kept the observations and cut the reflection would keep the lesser half of a title that promises both. The review standard set for it is a historian of biology together with a German reader. The gratitude factor is high, and easy to explain: this is a book its own field cites constantly and can barely read.

Sources

- https://embryo.asu.edu/pages/karl-ernst-von-baers-laws-embryology (ASU Embryo Project: the laws come from this work, 1828/1837; Huxley's Scientific Memoirs as the English channel)
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Von_Baer%27s_laws_(embryology) (the book and its argument; the anti-recapitulation intent)
- Internet Archive advanced search, 2026-10-14: title: (entwickelungsgeschichte) AND creator:(baer) — 15 items incl. the volume scans above.
- https://wellcomecollection.org/works/tharub39
- https://core.ac.uk/outputs/4524026/
- https://onlinebooks.library.upenn.edu/webbin/book/lookupid?key=ha006055138